

Exercise Plan for Arthritic Hands

Practical NHS-backed advice on printable exercise plan for arthritic hands.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: A daily hand exercise routine of 10–15 minutes significantly reduces pain, stiffness, and improves grip strength in arthritis. Key exercises: finger bends, fist-making, wrist rotations, thumb stretches, and finger spreads — all recommended by NHS physiotherapists and NICE guidance.

Arthritis in the hands responds well to regular gentle movement. The exercises below are based on NHS physiotherapy guidance and are safe for most people with hand arthritis.

Before You Start

Warm your hands first — a warm towel or bowl of warm water for 5 minutes reduces stiffness. Never exercise during a severe flare; wait until acute inflammation settles. Check with your physiotherapist if you have severe joint damage or recent hand surgery.

The Core Hand Exercise Plan



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Finger and Fist Exercises

- Finger bends (tendon gliding): Start with fingers straight, bend into a "hook" fist, straighten fully. 10 reps, twice daily
- Full fist: Slowly curl all fingers into a full fist, hold 3 seconds, open fully. 10 reps, twice daily
- Finger spread: Place hand flat on table, spread fingers as wide as possible, hold 5 seconds. 10 reps each hand

Thumb and Wrist Exercises

- Thumb opposition: Touch tip of thumb to tip of each finger in sequence, making a clean "O". 5 repetitions through full sequence

- Wrist circles: Rest forearm on surface, hand hanging over edge, slowly circle wrist 10 times each direction

How Often

Aim for this routine twice daily — morning to reduce stiffness, evening to maintain movement. Mild aching during exercise is normal; sharp or lasting pain is not and warrants review with your physiotherapist.

Q&A;



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Question: Can hand exercises make arthritis worse? **Short answer:** Gentle exercises within comfortable range do not worsen arthritis and are recommended by NICE. The key is to avoid

exercising during active flares and to stop if you experience sharp or lasting pain.

Question: How long before I notice improvement? **Short answer:** Most people notice reduced morning stiffness within 2–4 weeks of daily exercise. Grip strength improvements typically emerge after 6–8 weeks.

Question: Should I use heat or cold before hand exercises? **Short answer:** Heat before exercise helps loosen stiff joints. Cold after exercise can reduce post-exercise swelling. Never apply ice directly to skin.

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